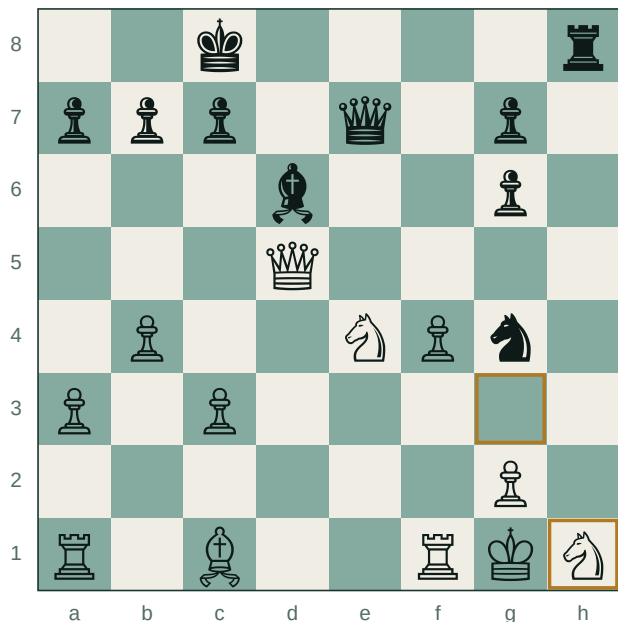


Mate in three: Black, move 21

Mate in three

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Nxh1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Rxh1+ 22. Kxh1 Qh4+ 23. Kg1 Qh2#

21...Rxh1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the knight on h1. Recorded reply: **22.Kxh1**.

22...Qh4+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **23.Kg1**.

23...Qh2# Mate: queen on h2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on h2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d5 and rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.